ability to attack bowlers and play shots from the word go, and in the one-day game, the key was to take advantage of the field restrictions in the first fifteen overs. I was sure that I just needed a chance to prove myself. I told Wadekar Sir that if I failed I'd never ask him again. In any case, there was no reserve opener in the team and they had no choice but to experiment with an irregular opener in place of Sidhu. If they put me at the top, they could still get a middle-order batsman to fill in for me at number four or five. After a lot of pleading, they finally agreed.

New Zealand scored just 142 batting first, but we still needed to make a good start. As I walked out to bat, I felt different in some way. I told myself that this was my big chance to open the batting for India. I did not want to let down the captain and the coach. Once I was at the wicket I cleared my mind and was just intent on hitting the ball hard, come what may. It was one of those days when everything fell into place and soon I couldn't wait for the next delivery. The quicker the better, as far as I was concerned. I managed to score 82 off forty-eight balls, finally holing out to the left-arm spinner Matthew Hart off a leading edge. I had hit fifteen fours and two sixes.

After that I no longer had to plead with Wadekar Sir to allow me to open and I continued to score runs in that position for the rest of the series, which ended up being tied 2–2. It was no surprise because New Zealand at home were always formidable opponents. In this series, I was able to dictate terms to the bowlers and all my plans were working out well. For example, against Gavin Larsen, known to be a bowler who bowled a stump-to-stump line, I came down the wicket a couple of times, forcing him to adjust his length. When he bowled short I was waiting for it and promptly dispatched the ball to the stands.

With one aim achieved, I was determined to accomplish the second as soon as possible. I had started to feel frustrated and a little embarrassed at not having scored a hundred in ODI cricket. Having already played seventy-odd games, it was about time. The moment finally came against Australia in Sri Lanka in the Singer World Series in September 1994 and it was more of a relief than anything else. So much of getting to a century is in the mind. Once you score one, you know you can score another and the doubts aren't there any more – getting the first one is the tricky bit. My first ODI hundred certainly soothed the nerves and it was an important milestone in my career.